

Understanding College Students' News Sharing Experience on Instagram

Luping Wang
Cornell University
lw636@cornell.edu

ABSTRACT

News sharing has become prevalent on social media platforms like Facebook and Twitter. Recent empirical works suggest a growing trend that young adults are using Instagram to access and share news. In this work, I explore college students' news sharing experience on Instagram through an in-depth qualitative interview. The study prompts participants to reflect on their recently shared news pieces to understand news types that get circulated, as well as reasons behind the choice of using Instagram for sharing such content. Research results revealed: news that can help college students to (1) express their opinions, (2) raise awareness of their friends and (3) spark conversations are more likely to be shared on Instagram. The primary mode of sharing is via Instagram stories. Instagram is popular for news sharing because of its convenience of use, easiness of reaching out to peers, and the natural affordance of delivering powerful visual messages. Applying this work as an empirical basis, I propose features that can be added to Instagram to facilitate users' news reading and sharing experiences.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing; • Human computer interaction (HCI); • Empirical studies in HCI;

KEYWORDS

Social media, Instagram, News sharing, Interview

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1 INTRODUCTION

According to a recent Pew study [11], 55% of survey participants reported they “often” or “sometimes” went to social networking services (SNS) like Facebook, Twitter and YouTube to consume news. In addition to reading, users also actively share news with their friends on those platforms [8]. The ease of sharing allows users to spread the information to hundreds and thousands of

people with a single click of the share button [1]. Though extensive research work has been focused on studying the news sharing behavior on Facebook and Twitter [5, 8, 14], recent works suggest that Instagram gains popularity as a platform for news consumption [2]. In light of these works, this current study plans to investigate the intersection between the news sharing behavior and Instagram: what is the news sharing experience for college students who are between 18 and 24 [17], one of the largest user groups of the platform?

To address this overarching research goal, I first reviewed the literature on why users share news on social media and what type of content is being circulated [5, 9]. Empirical works suggest there are distinct motivations behind social media information transmission [3], such as defending one's point of view, providing accurate and reliable information to others, and impression-relationship management. Lee & Ma [7] surveyed social media users and found news sharing could fulfill a variety of personal and social “gratifications”, including information seeking, entertainment, status-seeking and socializing. Those distinct motivations help people navigate what they would like to share, and on which platforms [8, 15]. Previous work further revealed that some news pieces get shared publicly, while others are shared within a group or through private messages [8, 14]. When it comes to Instagram news sharing, this work asks:

RQ1: what types of news content do users share on Instagram, and which mode of sharing is popular?

In previous work examining Instagram use, scholars found that people posted pictures and videos for self-expression purposes. At the same time, the goal of sparking conversations with others (“social interaction purposes”) also drove that sharing behavior [6]. More fine-grained uses of Instagram were revealed as it has grown in popularity in the past few years. In addition to documenting life, Instagram has been used for surveilling, self-disclosing [4] and seeking for mental and social support [12]. It is also not rare that organizations and activists use Instagram to spread messages to mobilize the public. In a most recent national survey by Pew [2], Instagram ranks as the fourth popular pathway for Internet users to access news, behind YouTube, Facebook and Twitter. Yet, less attention has been focused on underlying reasons why Instagram is chosen as a tool for news sharing. Thus, this work aims to answer:

RQ2: what are the reasons that people opt to share news on Instagram instead of other platforms?

Guided by these research questions, a qualitative interview study was conducted with college student participants at a large U.S. research university. In a recent national survey, Instagram ranks as one of the most popular social media platforms among college students [10]. Specifically, this study investigates the news content that got shared, motivations behind the sharing behavior, as well as why Instagram was chosen as the platform for sharing by this user

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group. Preliminary results suggest that: motivations of news sharing on Instagram are diverse. Instagram “stories” is the dominant way of sharing news content. Participants particularly choose Instagram to share because it allows them to reach out to peers by delivering powerful visual messages. Those results throw lights on future Instagram designs so that it can better serve as a channel for people to access and share news.

2 METHODS

The first author conducted in-depth, semi-structured interviews with 23 college students (5 males, 18 females; mean age = 19; age range: 18 – 23 years old) at a large northeastern U.S. university. Participants were recruited via an internal participant recruiting system. They were in different stages of the study: freshman (8), sophomore (8), junior (6) and senior (1). By inviting college students to talk about their recent news sharing content and experiences, this work aims to document the decision-making process of the sharing behavior, highlighting why it is chosen as the platform of sharing. Participants’ demographic backgrounds were diverse in terms of major (information science, computer science, engineering, communication, and art history) and self-reported ethnicity. They received a research credit or a monetary payment (\$10) upon finishing the Zoom interview. Only those who had Instagram news sharing experience in the past two weeks from registering the study were eligible. It is expected this participant group would be able to recall their latest sharing experiences during the interview. Participants reported that in general, they used Instagram in their spare time for keeping update with friends, posting pictures of their personal life and exploring topics they were interested in.

The semi-structured interview protocol follows the three stages of pre-, during-, and post- social media news sharing framework [14]. The interview started with ice-breaker questions about social media news consumption (e.g., “where do you often get news and what topics you’re interested in reading”). It then narrowed to questions related to participants’ Instagram use and news sharing experiences. They were then asked to locate the most recent piece of news they shared on Instagram (either a story, a regular post, or private messaging). After describing the news content and visual components, participants responded to prompts including why they shared the news piece, how they shared it (“could you describe the sharing process for this particular post?”), who the audience was (“when you decided to share this news piece, who did you have in mind to share it with?”) and the response they received (“how did your friends respond to this sharing?”). To obtain as rich reflection as possible, participants were asked why they chose Instagram to share instead of platforms like Facebook or Twitter. In the end, interviewees discussed what features they would like to add to enhance their news sharing experiences. The time of each interview was about 20 to 25 minutes.

The author and two research assistants used a modified grounded theory method to process the interview data. After transcribing all audio recordings, each person in the research team first coded a same set of interview transcripts (N = 5) in Atlas.Ti (a qualitative research software) [16] individually. During this round of initial open-coding, guided by interview questions, researchers assigned codes to important instances throughout transcripts. More than 50

codes were generated. Some examples were: “share to raise awareness,” “powerful visual message,” “share to spark conversation,” etc. After that, we sat together and compared the codes generated. Even for a same quote, different coders might assign codes differently. We discussed those and reached a consensus before proceeding to the next one. Then, using this refined codebook, we recoded the first batch of transcripts then the remaining ones. When new codes emerged during the second round of the coding process, we added them as necessary to ensure the comprehensiveness of the analysis. Lastly, the author organized codes into higher-level themes in response to the aforementioned research questions.

3 FINDINGS

3.1 News content shared on Instagram

To answer RQ1, I looked at the latest news pieces participants shared on their Instagram accounts. A majority of them (17 out of 23) were related to the broad topic of politics. Specific content included the Supreme Court justice nominee, local and nationwide policies, calling for voting, presidential election candidates’ campaigns, etc. It should be noted that this concentration of sharing political news might relate to the fact that the study was conducted during the 2020 U.S. presidential election. The rest of the postings mainly covered respondents’ interests such as sports, technology, entertainment, and campus updates. Instead of news reports, two participants shared the popular black square image during the Black Lives Matter movement, and they considered that to be an example of news sharing. Interestingly, there was only one piece of news related to the COVID-19 pandemic. Approximately half of the news pieces shared (12 out of 23) were screenshots directly taken from media outlets’ websites or their social media accounts.

When asked what led them to share the news, participants’ responses mainly fell under three categories. First, nine participants mentioned that news pieces that helped them express their viewpoints and attitudes were being shared. One participant elaborated that sharing allowed him to “stand in solidarity” with other social movement participants. Second, seven participants highlighted that the information they thought worth their Instagram friends knowing got shared. The goal was to raise awareness on the news topic, especially among peers. For example:

“(I share) just getting people out to vote, and making people like more aware of what’s going on around them and like, the potential for the future of the country and things like that.” (P5)

Lastly, five participants reported that the news content that could spark conversations got shared. While this was true for some participants, others expressed that they tended to avoid controversial and debatable content in their posts.

The dominant mode of news sharing (16 out of 23) was through “stories”. Participants preferred this approach because a story post “vanished in 24 hours” to the viewers. Users thus didn’t have to worry about the post being sticky to their accounts. Respondent also pointed out that they normally browsed “stories” before scrolling down to the main feed because the “stories” bar is on the top of the Instagram interface. Thus, posting stories was seen as an instant way to make the news visible to friends.

"I think it's a great place to because it goes away after 24 hours. So it's kind of more current news or updates." (P10)

Though users were allowed to add customizations to story postings such as filters, stickers, hand-drawings and polls, there were only a few examples ($N = 3$) using that strategy. Participants pointed out that they considered posting a piece of news a "formal action," thus they wanted to keep it "serious" rather than "beautiful".

In terms of feedback, participants expressed that the quality of comments they received mattered more than the quantity. Especially when the news content was shared via stories, the reply was a "private conversation" between the commentor and the sharer. Participants highlighted that when there was a comment, they treated it as "a good time to start a conversation" or even an "education" opportunity, though sometimes it became a debate.

"(For) people (who) disagree with me, I would love to talk to them about it. I think it'd be a benefit in this case." (P21)

3.2 Reasons for choosing Instagram to share news

Participants mentioned that they choose Instagram to share news mainly because of the access to peer networks, the power of visual content, and the ease of using the sharing function.

Access to peers. Comparing with other platforms, many participants expressed that on Instagram, they had more peers with whom they had close relationships ($N = 10$). While on other platforms, they had connections that were not in their same age groups, or a high number of acquaintances like on Facebook and Twitter. Thus, they felt more comfortable sharing news on Instagram, especially when the shared content suggested their personal emotions or attitudes on a public issue, such as politics. Further, participants claimed that sharing with peers avoided unfamiliar others (e.g., those who didn't share similar experiences) forming biases on them. As a result, when posting news to raise awareness on a specific topic, participants considered Instagram a more effective channel to reach out to, even persuade peers than other frequently used social networking services (SNS), due to the homophily nature of the network.

"That's probably the social media platform that my generation is most active on. So it gets the most, viewership." (P16)

Powerful visual messages. Participants enjoyed reading and sharing news on Instagram because the presentation is visually appealing ($N = 8$). When the sharing goal was calling to actions, image- and video-based content was considered to be more "inspiring," "inciting" and "powerful" than a regular news piece shared on other SNS, where additional details like texts, or social cues like the number of likes and comments distracted the readers from focusing on the news content itself. Some examples are: participants posted images in their stories to encourage their friends to vote for the presidential election, or re-shared a video story that showed the crowd marching together to raise awareness of some recent social activism events. Sharing news on Instagram is also helpful for story-telling. Users can choose to publish multiple images and videos

at the same time in the story to deliver a comprehensive pack of messages to the audience.

"I like being able to see visual posts about information, whether it's pictures or just infographics. I feel like I'm very much like a visual learner and I think my peers are visual persons as well. So Instagram is the best option for me." (P14)

Ease of sharing. Participants suggested that they spent substantial time on Instagram every day. Thus, it is convenient for them to share news on it, rather than switching to a different platform ($N = 6$). When participants were tagged in a story, Instagram allows them to forward it directly to their own stories, making it easy for sharing. For example, one got mentioned in a local news story that a child was missing. She then re-shared this story with one-click and mentioned her other friends to spread the information further. Another typical sharing scenario is that when users saw other accounts (e.g., media accounts) posted the news content they felt worth sharing: they tapped the "add post to your story" button to add the image or video to their own stories. This function was described as "immediate" and "intuitive".

"Instagram has lots of features that enable sharing really easily like the stories and DM feature. A lot of people are creating content and sharing content, surrounding news especially." (P13)

4 DISCUSSION

Much of recent research attention has been focusing on the phenomenon of news sharing on platforms like Facebook and Twitter [5, 8, 14]. Yet, a growing number of Instagram users, especially those who are 18-24, are using it to access and share news [2]. When explaining why Instagram was chosen for news sharing, in addition to the consideration of convenience, participants also emphasized that the platform largely represented their peer network. As a result, it was perceived to be less risky to share news that unveiled their authentic opinions and attitudes on it when compared with other SNS. Participants also suggested that "occasionally" posting news would catch their friends' attention. Pathways to news sharing on Instagram were diverse. Participants shared both: (1) what they read from news media outlets' websites or social media accounts by snapping screenshots and (2) news pieces posted by their friends by using native Instagram tools and functions. "Stories" was the primary way of sharing. The responses one received such as likes and comments via stories were private. Participants agreed that they did not intentionally expect feedbacks, but when there were replies from friends, they took this as an opportunity to start in-depth conversations.

This study was conducted during the 2020 U.S. presidential election. Many most-recent news pieces shared by participants were about politics. This finding resonates with previous literature that social media opens a forum for its users to express political preferences and beliefs. However, the fact that a specific political event occupied public attention for an extended time might influence this observation. Future research can investigate: during a different data collection period, what news topics and content do college students share? Qualitative researchers can also examine whether this research's outcomes (such as motivations) hold for different

age or demographic groups. Moreover, with the increasing popularity of TikTok among young users, a comparison study between this platform and Instagram from the perspective news sharing would be helpful. Lastly, to better summarize the pattern of news sharing on Instagram, scholars can conduct quantitative survey studies with more users.

More than half of participants expressed that they hoped Instagram to allow them to add clickable links for news pieced shared. Ideally, when the readers want to learn more details about a news story, they can access the full article by following the link provided by the sharer. Currently, this feature is only available to verified accounts or those who have followers more than 10,000. However, there is also a risk that the hyperlink function being “hijacked,” particularly by those who intentionally spread misinformation or conspiracy theories.

Correcting the spread of misinformation has become an urgent task of many social network services [1, 13]. Previous studies suggested that people in general didn’t fully trust the news content they read on Instagram [2]. Yet, chances are users encounter fake news they have a hard time telling whether it is true or false. To combat that, Instagram algorithm can perform image recognition of posts and stories, then direct the news-reading audience to credible sources of the recognized topic. For example, if one user posts an image with COVID-19 vaccine-related content, the link to the CDC (Center for Disease Control and Prevention) verified Instagram account or official website would be displayed by default.

5 CONCLUSION

This qualitative research work with college students offers the first insight into how this demographic group uses Instagram to share news. Interview results suggest that key motivations that drive this behavior include: express personal opinions, raise awareness among peers and spark potential conversations. During the 2020 U.S. presidential election, college students mostly shared political content that aligned with their beliefs or reflected their points of view. “Stories” was the primary mode of sharing. It is found that participants chose Instagram to share news because they could utilize the power of visuals to reach out to peers on this platform. To enhance the experience, users agreed that Instagram could allow them to incorporate external links when posting news content. Future works can attend to address this research topic quantitatively and expand the participant group beyond college students.

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